

Good garden hygiene

By keeping your plants in good health and checking them regularly, you can keep many pests and diseases at bay. Aim to grow your plants in the right conditions because healthy specimens are more able to withstand attacks. Remember, too, that some plants are susceptible to certain diseases so, whenever possible, buy resistant varieties.

A few simple precautions will also pay dividends. Check new plants for signs of pests and diseases to ensure that they do not introduce them to your garden, and keep all tools and equipment clean to guard against the spread of diseases. Tools such as pruners and seed trays are best cleaned with household disinfectant. You can also put up physical barriers, such as cut-off plastic bottles to help protect your plants from pests such as slugs and snails.

If a plant does succumb to a disease, first try to identify the problem to gauge its seriousness, and remove and either burn or discard infected plant material. Minor pest attacks can usually be dealt with by removing the invaders by hand. Also, try to encourage natural predators, such as birds, frogs and toads, ladybugs, hoverflies, spiders, and lacewings into your garden, as together they will help to keep many pests under control. Pools, ponds, berried shrubs and trees, and nectar-rich open flowers will help to lure this pest

army into your plot. If you have to resort to chemical pesticides and fungicides, use them sparingly and read the manufacturer's instructions carefully.

Pruning guidelines

It is not essential to prune any plant, but thinning and cutting back to varying degrees or selectively removing entire branches can be beneficial.

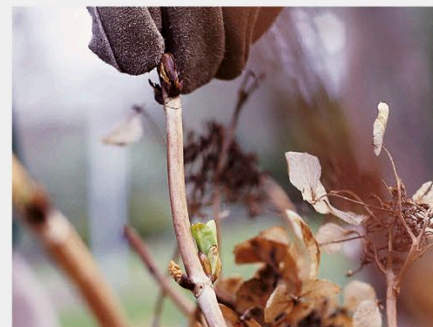
Pruning can rejuvenate old, congested specimens and help to extend the life of short-lived shrubs. It can also promote the growth of more flowering and fruiting wood, improve the shape of a plant, and reduce the incidence of disease.

Most pruning is performed annually, but if you spot dead, damaged, or diseased wood, or a sucker growing from a grafted plant, remove it immediately. A general tip is to prune plants that flower in spring just after they have bloomed, and prune those that flower in summer or fall in early spring before the buds break. Most evergreens are pruned in late spring.

It is important to use the right tools when pruning, as they will make the task easier. The tool you will require depends on the thickness of the material you need to remove. Use sharp pruners for stems the width of a pencil or smaller, and a pruning saw or loppers for larger branches. Never prune above head height and call in a professional tree surgeon for large jobs.

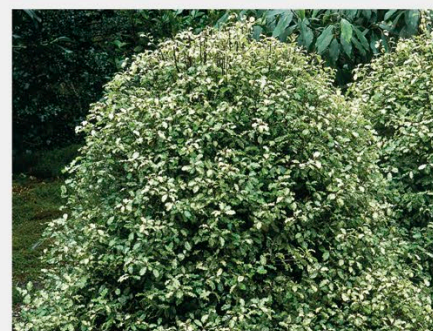
WHY PRUNE?

You can achieve many beautiful effects with careful pruning. Some plants are best trimmed lightly to create a natural look, while others can be clipped into elegant topiary. In addition, some pruning techniques encourage more flowering and fruiting stems to form.



Cutting out dead and diseased wood

Whenever you see dead or diseased wood on any woody plant, remove it immediately. If dead wood is left on a plant, disease can enter more easily and move down the stems.



Pruning for shape and form

Some plants need a gentle trim to retain their shape. This *Pittosporum tenuifolium* makes an attractive focal plant. The only pruning it requires is to retain the plant's symmetry by lightly trimming it in late spring.



Crossing and rubbing branches

Branches that rub each other can create open wounds that let in diseases. Remove one of the branches, choosing the weakest one or the stem that has suffered the most damage.

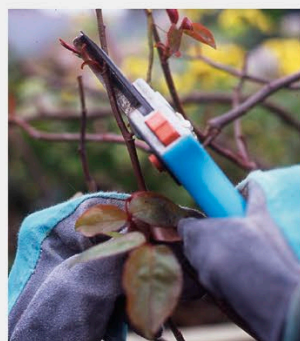
MAKING PRUNING CUTS

Trees, shrubs, and climbers grow in different ways, and their shoots, buds, and stems differ, too. Before pruning, identify the type of buds and shoots on the plant and their position. Buds are found at the point where the leaves are about to grow, or where they have previously been attached to the stem. When pruning, cut just above a bud; this stimulates hormones that make the bud develop into a new stem.



Cutting opposite buds

The buds of some plants are opposite each other. Prune above a pair of buds with a flat, straight cut. When the buds grow, they will produce two shoots growing in opposite directions from one another.



Cutting alternate buds

Where the buds are positioned alternately along the stems, try to prune to one that is facing outward, away from the center of the plant. Make a sloping cut above the bud, so that water runs away from it.



Cutting to new growth

You can recognize new growth because it looks much fresher than old wood. When pruning, cut off old wood just above a new stem, using a sloping cut so that water runs away from the young growth.